ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · August 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	80.3
#2	A+	Hartford	77.3
#3	A+	Charlotte	74.6
#4	A+	Cincinnati	74.4
#5	A+	Kansas City	72.5
#6	A+	Nashville	71.5
#7	A+	Salt Lake City	68.4

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Louisville	17.7
#49	C-	Grand Rapids	27.1
#48	C-	Chicago	28.2
#47	C-	Detroit	29.2
#46	C-	Richmond	31.6
#45	C-	Sacramento	31.9
#44	C	Indianapolis	34.8

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	12 cities
B+ / B / B-	19 cities
C+ / C / C-	18 cities
D	1 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · August 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	**Raleigh** Raleigh-Cary	A+	80.3	3.1%	+3.8%	+2.6%	+0.4%	50 days
2	**Hartford** Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A+	77.3	2.7%	+4.7%	+1.9%	+2.8%	29 days
3	**Charlotte** Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A+	74.6	3.6%	+4.7%	+1.6%	+0.3%	51 days
4	**Cincinnati** Cincinnati	A+	74.4	3.9%	+6.4%	+1.1%	+0.1%	37 days
5	**Kansas City** Kansas City	A+	72.5	3.7%	+7.7%	+0.8%	+0.5%	45 days
6	**Nashville** Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A+	71.5	3.3%	+6.0%	+1.6%	-0.1%	53 days
7	**Salt Lake City** Salt Lake City-Murray	A+	68.4	3.6%	+4.2%	+2.7%	+1.0%	50 days
8	**St. Louis** St. Louis	A	64.8	3.8%	+2.0%	+0.4%	+0.7%	44 days
9	**Atlanta** Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	A	64.2	3.5%	+3.1%	+0.4%	+1.9%	52 days
10	**Austin** Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A-	62.3	4.1%	+4.7%	+1.9%	+1.3%	63 days
11	**Pittsburgh** Pittsburgh	A-	60.0	3.8%	+5.6%	+0.1%	+2.5%	47 days
12	**San Jose** San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	A-	59.4	4.0%	+0.3%	+1.4%	-0.6%	37 days
13	**Orlando** Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B+	58.7	4.6%	+5.0%	+1.4%	+1.7%	70 days
14	**Memphis** Memphis	B+	57.8	4.8%	+9.0%	+0.2%	-1.4%	64 days
15	**Las Vegas** Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	B+	57.4	5.2%	+4.5%	+2.9%	+0.2%	55 days
16	**Philadelphia** Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B	53.8	4.1%	+0.7%	+0.6%	+2.0%	39 days
17	**Columbus** Columbus	B	53.8	3.3%	+3.5%	+0.4%	-0.4%	39 days
18	**Baltimore** Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	B-	50.0	4.0%	+3.9%	-0.4%	+1.2%	36 days
19	**Tampa** Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B-	49.7	4.7%	+5.6%	+0.2%	+0.5%	68 days
20	**San Francisco** San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B-	49.6	4.2%	+6.2%	+0.6%	-1.6%	37 days
21	**San Diego** San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B-	49.5	4.4%	+7.2%	+1.1%	-1.3%	43 days
22	**Birmingham** Birmingham	B-	49.4	3.7%	+0.6%	+1.0%	-0.3%	54 days
23	**New York** New York Newark-Jersey City	B-	48.6	4.5%	+2.8%	+0.7%	+1.2%	47 days
24	**Seattle** Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B-	48.6	5.0%	+6.4%	+0.3%	-1.0%	37 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	**Denver** Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B-	47.5	3.9%	+2.0%	+0.6%	-2.1%	48 days
26	**Cleveland** Cleveland	B-	47.1	3.4%	-0.3%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
27	**Dallas** Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B-	46.2	4.7%	+1.9%	+1.3%	N/A	51 days
28	**Oklahoma City** Oklahoma City	B-	45.6	4.2%	+5.1%	+0.1%	-0.0%	51 days
29	**Los Angeles** Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B-	45.5	5.0%	+3.6%	+1.8%	-2.2%	50 days
30	**Boston** Boston-Cambridge-Newton	B-	45.1	3.9%	+3.2%	+0.4%	+2.9%	37 days
31	**Washington DC** Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	B-	44.7	4.1%	+5.2%	-2.4%	-1.7%	36 days
32	**Milwaukee** Milwaukee-Waukesha	C+	43.4	3.8%	+1.6%	-0.4%	+1.7%	33 days
33	**Virginia Beach** Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C+	41.4	4.0%	+5.9%	-0.6%	-1.1%	37 days
34	**Houston** Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	C+	41.3	5.2%	+1.5%	+1.1%	+0.9%	50 days
35	**Miami** Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	C+	41.3	3.9%	+6.9%	+0.2%	-0.1%	82 days
36	**Phoenix** Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	C+	40.0	4.9%	+2.4%	+1.4%	-2.7%	64 days
37	**Providence** Providence-Warwick	C	37.6	4.3%	+3.0%	+0.6%	+1.7%	32 days
38	**Minneapolis** Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C	36.9	4.4%	+0.0%	+1.5%	-1.0%	37 days
39	**Fresno** Fresno	C	36.8	7.7%	+6.0%	+1.6%	-1.7%	55 days
40	**Riverside** Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C	36.4	5.3%	+6.2%	+0.7%	-1.9%	59 days
41	**Portland** Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C	35.8	5.0%	+5.8%	-2.1%	-0.8%	51 days
42	**Jacksonville** Jacksonville	C	35.7	4.8%	-0.7%	+0.3%	+0.8%	59 days
43	**San Antonio** San Antonio-New Braunfels	C	34.9	4.8%	+1.3%	+0.6%	+0.2%	61 days
44	**Indianapolis** Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C	34.8	3.4%	-0.7%	-1.3%	+0.2%	45 days
45	**Sacramento** Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C-	31.9	4.8%	+1.1%	+0.7%	-1.4%	43 days
46	**Richmond** Richmond	C-	31.6	3.8%	+2.6%	-0.7%	-0.8%	37 days
47	**Detroit** Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C-	29.2	5.4%	+1.1%	-0.2%	+2.7%	38 days
48	**Chicago** Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C-	28.2	5.3%	+3.2%	+0.1%	-0.5%	33 days
49	**Grand Rapids** Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C-	27.1	4.2%	+2.0%	-0.3%	-8.8%	33 days
50	**Louisville** Louisville-Jefferson County	D	17.7	5.2%	+1.2%	-0.5%	+0.1%	40 days

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #1 OF 50

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

80.3th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	98
Unemployment	20% weight	94
Wage Growth	15% weight	52
Cost of Living	12% weight	86
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	59
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	86
Days on Market	5% weight	30
Office Economy	3% weight	98

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+2.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+31.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	50 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area boasts an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 80.3th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 98th percentile, driven by a 2.64% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.410% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. The combination of strong employment growth and increased hours worked signals genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area exhibits a robust labor demand, with a 2.64% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.410% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs at a rapid pace and workers are putting in more hours to meet the growing demand. The labor demand composite score of 9.41 further reinforces this notion, placing the city in the top tier of labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary stands at 3.10%, which corresponds to a top-tier percentile rank of 94th. This low unemployment rate signifies a tight labor market, making it more challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, companies may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent in this competitive job market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Raleigh-Cary is 3.78%, placing it near the median at the 52nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. While this may put some pressure on businesses, it also translates to increased purchasing power for workers, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 86th, Raleigh-Cary is relatively affordable compared to its peer cities. The city's price-to-salary ratio is $218/sqft to $37.84/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.76. The fact that the PSF is decreasing by 2.2% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability. This makes Raleigh-Cary an attractive location for businesses looking to recruit talent without having to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a year-over-year rate of 0.37%, which is near the median at the 59th percentile. Although this growth rate is not exceptionally high, it still indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing businesses with a gradually increasing pool of potential employees to hire from.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Raleigh-Cary has increased by 31.25% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This significant rise in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should help improve affordability and accommodate the city's growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 50 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast pace of home sales, corresponding to a below-average percentile rank of 30th, indicates a competitive housing market. However, the lack of change in days on market suggests a stable and accessible environment for workers relocating to the city.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary boasts a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 98th. This makes the city an ideal location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on specialized knowledge workers. On the other hand, the city may be less suited for industries with predominantly industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, moderate wage growth, and relatively low cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the tight labor market and resulting upward pressure on wages pose a significant risk that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this city as a potential business location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #2 OF 50

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A+

EXCELLENT

77.3th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	84
Unemployment	20% weight	98
Wage Growth	15% weight	62
Cost of Living	12% weight	71
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	96
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	78
Days on Market	5% weight	4
Office Economy	3% weight	40

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **2.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.7%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.9%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+2.8%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+18.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **29 days** median, +3.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 77.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 2.70% and its strong labor demand composite score of 6.34, which ranks in the 84th percentile. The combination of a top-tier labor demand score and low unemployment rate suggests a highly competitive job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +1.88% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.593% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs and hours are running slightly below trend, indicating a healthy and sustainable pace of growth. The labor demand composite score of 6.34 reinforces this signal, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 2.70%, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This extremely low rate indicates a very tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire and retain talent. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain employees in this competitive market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +4.73%, ranking above average at the 62nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace. At the same time, workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a cost of living score ranking in the 71st percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $254/sqft to $39.99/hr, or 6.35. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, although the ratio is rising slightly at +0.8% year-over-year. The relatively high affordability score suggests that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is growing at a rate of +2.77% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This strong labor force growth indicates that the supply of workers is expanding, which can help businesses meet their hiring needs and reduce the risk of labor shortages.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is increasing at a rate of +18.05% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This rise in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can help improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is currently 29 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.6%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, indicates a competitive market that may be challenging for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a professional and office worker share ranking near the median at the 40th percentile, with a composite score of 2.14. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it suitable for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations, although it may not be as strong as other cities in these sectors.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a highly competitive and growing labor market, with a strong talent pool and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the extremely tight labor market, which can drive up wages and make it challenging to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #3 OF 50

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

A+

EXCELLENT

74.6th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	92
Unemployment	20% weight	86
Wage Growth	15% weight	60
Cost of Living	12% weight	84
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	57
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	40
Days on Market	5% weight	66
Office Economy	3% weight	78

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.3%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-5.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	51 days	median, +6.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 74.6th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 92nd percentile, and its low unemployment rate of 3.60%, ranking in the 86th percentile. The combination of a +1.57% employment growth rate and +0.970% weekly hours deviation from trend signals genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has seen a +1.57% employment growth rate year-over-year, combined with a +0.970% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month trend. This signals a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 7.47 ranks in the 92nd percentile, indicating a strong job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 3.60%, ranking in the 86th percentile, which indicates a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With a low unemployment rate, employers may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is +4.70%, ranking in the 60th percentile, which is above average but not exceptionally high. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace, while workers are seeing an increase in their purchasing power. As wages continue to grow, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has a cost of living score ranking in the 84th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $221/sqft to $38.03/hr, or 5.81. The fact that the PSF is falling by -1.3% year-over-year relative to wages makes this city more affordable. This high affordability score means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring excessive wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has grown by +0.33% year-over-year, ranking in the 57th percentile, which is near the median. This slow growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, but at a moderate pace. While this growth is positive, it may not be sufficient to meet the demands of a rapidly expanding job market, potentially leading to hiring challenges.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has decreased by -5.10% year-over-year, ranking in the 40th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As the city's job market continues to expand, the lack of new housing supply may become a constraint.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is currently 51 days, with a +6.2% year-over-year increase, ranking in the 66th percentile. This indicates a relatively accessible market for workers relocating to the city, as homes are not selling extremely quickly. However, the rising days on market may signal a normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 3.28, ranking in the 78th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy workers, but may be less ideal for industries with primarily industrial or logistics-based workforces.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a tight but not extremely competitive unemployment environment, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, potentially offsetting the city's many economic advantages.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #4 OF 50

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A+

EXCELLENT

74.4th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	48
Unemployment	20% weight	92
Wage Growth	15% weight	88
Cost of Living	12% weight	92
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	49
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	88
Days on Market	5% weight	96
Office Economy	3% weight	42

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+47.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	37 days	median, +15.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 74.4th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.90% and strong wage growth of +6.37% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. These metrics suggest that Cincinnati is an attractive location for businesses looking for a skilled workforce, but may require strategic hiring and compensation planning.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is +1.08% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.694% below trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.12, near the median. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as the city is adding jobs, but hours worked are slightly below trend. This suggests that businesses can find talent, but may need to offer competitive compensation to attract and retain workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.90%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. However, this also suggests that the local consumer demand is strong, driven by a large number of employed residents.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cincinnati is +6.37% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees have more disposable income to spend on goods and services. However, it also means that businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, potentially impacting their bottom line.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati has a cost of living score of $194/sqft vs $35.18/hr, with a ratio of 5.51, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, indicating a very affordable city. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums, as the cost of living is relatively low compared to other US metros. This is a significant advantage for businesses looking to relocate or expand in the city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is growing at a rate of +0.14% year-over-year, near the median. This slow growth rate suggests that the labor pool is expanding, but at a moderate pace, which may impact hiring capacity for businesses. However, this also means that the city is not experiencing a significant brain drain, and the existing workforce is relatively stable.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Cincinnati is increasing by +47.86% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating a significant expansion of housing supply. This suggests that the city is experiencing a surge in developer confidence, which will lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to relocate or expand in the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Cincinnati is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of +15.6%, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. This is a positive sign for businesses, as it suggests that their employees will have an easier time finding housing.

Office Economy

Cincinnati has an office economy score of 2.18, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile, indicating a moderate depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office workers, but may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, strong wage growth, and affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses looking for a skilled workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential challenge of hiring and retaining talent in a competitive labor market, which may require strategic compensation and benefits planning.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #5 OF 50

Kansas City

Kansas City

A+

EXCELLENT

72.5th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	72
Unemployment	20% weight	80
Wage Growth	15% weight	96
Cost of Living	12% weight	90
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	61
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	50
Days on Market	5% weight	30
Office Economy	3% weight	24

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+7.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.8%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.5%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-1.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	45 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 72.5th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 5.77, and its high wage growth rate of 7.70% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and increasing labor costs.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate is 0.84% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of 0.296% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.77 is above average, ranking in the 72nd percentile.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate is 3.70%, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This tight labor market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages. With a low unemployment rate, Kansas City's labor market has limited slack, making it essential for companies to offer competitive compensation packages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Kansas City's year-over-year wage growth rate is 7.70%, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As wages continue to rise, businesses may need to adjust their budgets to accommodate higher labor costs, while workers will benefit from increased disposable income.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $197/sqft to $35.67/hr, Kansas City ranks in the top tier at the 90th percentile, indicating a relatively affordable city. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs. The city's affordability is a major advantage in attracting and retaining workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is growing at a rate of 0.50% year-over-year, ranking in the 61st percentile. This moderate growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, although at a slower pace than some other metros. As the labor force continues to grow, businesses will have access to a increasing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The city's residential building permits have decreased by 1.26% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply may be tightening, which could lead to future affordability challenges and impact the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce. As the demand for housing continues to rise, the limited supply may drive up prices and rents.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Kansas City is 45 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast market means that workers relocating to the city may face competition for available homes, making it essential for them to act quickly when finding a property. The stable days on market indicates a balanced housing market, neither overly competitive nor excessively slow.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share is 1.68, ranking below average at the 24th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses requiring specialized office or professional skills. The city is better suited for industries with less reliance on professional services, such as logistics or manufacturing, rather than tech, finance, or consulting.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a strong labor market with growing demand, increasing wages, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential tightening of the housing market, which could lead to future affordability challenges and impact the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #6 OF 50

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A+

EXCELLENT

71.5th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	86
Unemployment	20% weight	86
Wage Growth	15% weight	82
Cost of Living	12% weight	61
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	41
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	40
Days on Market	5% weight	48
Office Economy	3% weight	88

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.3%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+6.0%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+1.6%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	**-0.1%**	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	**-5.1%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**53 days**	median, +1.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 71.5th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier labor demand, with an 86th percentile ranking, and its strong wage growth, at +5.97% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a robust job market and increasing labor costs.

Labor Demand

The city's employment growth rate is +1.56% year-over-year, combined with a -0.141% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in slightly fewer hours than trend, suggesting a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.34 further reinforces this assessment, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is 3.30%, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile, which means the market is tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages. With such a low unemployment rate, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the city is +5.97%, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This rapid increase in wages suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, while worker purchasing power is also increasing. As a result, businesses should be prepared for higher labor costs, but also benefit from a workforce with growing disposable income.

Cost of Living

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has a cost of living score ranking in the 61st percentile, with a PSF of $260/sqft and average hourly earnings of $35.48/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.33. Although not the most affordable, the city's cost of living is relatively manageable, which can be an advantage for talent attraction without requiring significant wage premiums. The -1.1% year-over-year change in PSF also suggests some improvement in affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the city is growing at a rate of -0.14% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 41st percentile. This slight contraction in labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is not expanding. Businesses should be aware of this trend when planning their hiring strategies.

Building Permits

The city has experienced a -5.10% year-over-year change in residential building permits, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and impact the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce. This trend bears watching, as it may affect the attractiveness of the city for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is 53 days, with a +1.9% year-over-year increase. This relatively moderate pace of home sales, combined with the slight increase in days on market, suggests a competitive but still accessible market for workers relocating to the city. However, this trend should be monitored, as it may shift in response to changes in the job market or housing supply.

Office Economy

The city's professional and office worker share is 3.92, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool. This makes Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industries with primarily industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin offers a business a robust job market with strong wage growth, a tight labor market, and a relatively manageable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the slight contraction in labor force supply, which may pose challenges for hiring and require strategic planning to attract and retain top talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #7 OF 50

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A+

EXCELLENT

68.4th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	90
Unemployment	20% weight	80
Wage Growth	15% weight	56
Cost of Living	12% weight	57
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	71
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	16
Days on Market	5% weight	60
Office Economy	3% weight	96

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+2.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-21.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	50 days	median, +4.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 68.4th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 90th percentile, and its deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 96th percentile. The combination of a 2.73% employment growth rate and a -0.912% weekly hours deviation from trend suggests genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has seen a 2.73% employment growth rate year-over-year, combined with a -0.912% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend. This signals a genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend during job growth, indicating that the labor market is absorbing new workers without overburdening existing ones. The labor demand composite score of 7.21 further supports this interpretation, placing it in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 3.60%, which is in the top tier, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that wage pressure may be higher in this area.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Salt Lake City-Murray is 4.19%, which is near the median. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit not at a rapid pace. This balance may be beneficial for businesses looking to manage labor costs while still attracting and retaining talent.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 57th, Salt Lake City-Murray is relatively near the median in terms of affordability, considering its PSF of $266/sqft and average hourly earnings of $38.98/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.82. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor overly expensive compared to its peers, suggesting that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent from other areas.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray has grown by 0.96% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the hiring capacity for businesses is likely to improve, as more workers are available to fill positions, reducing the structural headwinds for hiring.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Salt Lake City-Murray has decreased by 21.89% year-over-year, signaling a tightening in housing supply. This sharp decline in permits may indicate future affordability challenges and potential difficulties in accommodating a growing workforce, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

Homes in Salt Lake City-Murray are currently sitting on the market for a median of 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.2%. This suggests a slightly slower market, which could be beneficial for workers relocating to the area, as they may have more time to find a suitable home without facing extreme competition.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranked in the 96th percentile, Salt Lake City-Murray has a deep and specialized talent pool, making it highly suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. This city is less suited for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant, given its strong emphasis on knowledge-economy jobs.

In conclusion, Salt Lake City-Murray offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a deep professional talent pool, and moderate wage growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the sharp decline in building permits, which may lead to future affordability challenges and difficulties in accommodating a growing workforce, potentially impacting the city's attractiveness for both businesses and relocating workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #8 OF 50

St. Louis

St. Louis

A

VERY GOOD

64.8th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	62
Unemployment	20% weight	78
Wage Growth	15% weight	30
Cost of Living	12% weight	76
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	65
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	76
Days on Market	5% weight	94
Office Economy	3% weight	42

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+16.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	44 days	median, +10.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis earns an overall grade of A, ranking in the 64.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and low unemployment rate defining its current economic character. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.59 and unemployment rate of 3.80% signal a tight labor market. Specifically, the employment growth rate of +0.44% and weekly hours deviation of +0.672% indicate genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.44% and weekly hours deviation of +0.672% suggest that St. Louis is experiencing genuine demand expansion, with more jobs being added and hours running above trend. This combination signals a healthy labor market, where businesses are hiring and workers are putting in more hours. The labor demand composite score of 5.59, ranking in the 62nd percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.80% indicates a tight labor market, ranking in the 78th percentile. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.03% is below average, ranking in the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace. While this may be beneficial for workers' purchasing power, it also indicates that workers may not have strong bargaining power.

Cost of Living

St. Louis has a cost of living score ranking in the 76th percentile, with a PSF of $164/sqft and an average hourly earnings of $37.27/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.40. The fact that PSF is falling by -1.2% YoY makes the city more affordable. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.69% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that businesses will have access to a growing pool of potential employees, making it easier to hire and staff their operations.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +16.20%, ranking in the 76th percentile. This significant increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive signal for businesses considering relocation, as it indicates a city that can support a growing population.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.0%, ranking in the 94th percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it a more accessible market for relocating workers. However, this also indicates a potential normalization of the market, rather than a highly competitive one.

Office Economy

The office economy in St. Louis has a percentile rank of 42, indicating a near-median depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a moderate level of specialized office workers, but may not be the best fit for those requiring a highly specialized or deep talent pool, such as tech or finance companies.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a strong labor market, low unemployment rate, and affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies considering relocation. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the moderate wage growth rate, which may impact labor costs and worker purchasing power.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #9 OF 50

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

A

VERY GOOD

64.2th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	70
Unemployment	20% weight	72
Wage Growth	15% weight	42
Cost of Living	12% weight	47
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	88
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	72
Days on Market	5% weight	50
Office Economy	3% weight	64

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.5%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.1%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.4%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.9%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+15.2%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **52 days** median, +2.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 64.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and labor force growth, which stand at 70th and 88th percentiles, respectively. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.66, combining a +0.41% employment growth rate and a +0.789% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its top-tier labor force growth, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.41% and weekly hours deviation of +0.789% indicate a genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a period of economic growth, with employers adding jobs and workers putting in more hours. The labor demand composite score of 5.66 further reinforces this notion, placing the city above average in terms of labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.50% is relatively low, ranking in the 72nd percentile, which means the job market is tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer unemployed workers available, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.15% is near the median, ranking in the 42nd percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. Workers, on the other hand, are seeing their purchasing power increase, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 5.39, based on $198/sqft and $36.71/hr, and a percentile rank of 47th, the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. This affordability, driven by a stable PSF-to-earnings ratio, makes it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The city's affordability can be a major draw for businesses looking to attract and retain workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.93% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city has a strong pipeline of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations. The top-tier labor force growth rate is a significant advantage for companies looking to grow their workforce.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +15.16%, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This increase in permits suggests that developers are confident in the city's future growth prospects, which can lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. The rising permits are a positive sign for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.0%. This relatively moderate days on market suggests that the housing market is not overly competitive, making it accessible for relocating workers to find housing. The slow increase in days on market may indicate a healthy normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 3.06, ranking in the 64th percentile, the city has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes it an attractive location for businesses in these sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies. The city's professional talent pool is a significant asset for businesses looking to establish or expand their operations.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, with genuine demand expansion and a growing workforce supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to hire and expand. However, the tight job market and moderate wage growth may pose challenges for businesses in terms of hiring and labor costs, and decision-makers should factor in these constraints when considering the city as a potential location. Overall, the city's unique combination of labor demand, labor force growth, and affordability makes it a compelling choice for businesses in the right sectors.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #10 OF 50

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A-

GOOD

62.3th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	88
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	64
Cost of Living	12% weight	96
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	78
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	2
Days on Market	5% weight	24
Office Economy	3% weight	94

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.3%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-37.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	63 days	median, +8.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 62.3th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 88th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 96th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.89% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.596% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.89% and the -0.596% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend signal a genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend despite job growth. This combination indicates that the labor market is experiencing organic growth rather than a survivor squeeze. The top-tier ranking of the labor demand composite score further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate stands at 4.10%, which is below average, ranking at the 36th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some level of competition for talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is 4.74%, which is above average, ranking at the 64th percentile. This indicates moderate to fast wage growth, suggesting that labor costs for employers are rising. On the other hand, workers in this metro area are experiencing an increase in their purchasing power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $237/sqft to $37.55/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 8.1% in PSF, this city is highly affordable, ranking at the 96th percentile. This affordability advantage is a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing large premiums to offset the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 1.27% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 78th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -37.80%, ranking at the 2nd percentile, indicating a sharp decline. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 63 days, with a year-over-year increase of 8.6%. This indicates a slightly slower market, ranking at the 24th percentile. For workers relocating to this city, the market is somewhat more accessible than faster-moving markets, but the trend suggests it may be becoming more competitive.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 4.22, ranking at the 94th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy talent but may be less ideal for those with primarily industrial or logistics-oriented operations.

In conclusion, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, moderate wage growth, and a highly affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which signals potential future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #11 OF 50

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

A-

GOOD

60.0th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	26
Unemployment	20% weight	84
Wage Growth	15% weight	74
Cost of Living	12% weight	63
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	92
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	66
Days on Market	5% weight	22
Office Economy	3% weight	36

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+2.5%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+13.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	47 days	median, -2.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 60.0th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.80% and its above-average wage growth of 5.61% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a tight labor market with rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is 0.06% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation is -0.272% below its own trend. This combination signals a labor demand contraction, as the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and hours worked are below the trend. This suggests that the labor market is not experiencing genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.80%, ranking it at the 84th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent and may need to offer higher wages to attract workers. The low unemployment rate implies a seller's market for labor.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Pittsburgh is 5.61% year-over-year, which is above average and ranks at the 74th percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. Businesses should factor in higher labor costs when considering Pittsburgh as a location.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh's cost of living is above average, with a PSF of $174/sqft and an earnings ratio of 5.27, ranking it at the 63rd percentile. This means that the city is not particularly affordable relative to its peers. However, the relatively stable cost of living means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent from other cities.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of 2.55% year-over-year, which is a top-tier growth rate ranking at the 92nd percentile. This means that the labor force supply is expanding, making it easier for businesses to hire and find talent in the city. The growing labor force is a significant advantage for businesses considering Pittsburgh as a location.

Building Permits

Building permits in Pittsburgh are increasing at a rate of 13.14% year-over-year, which is an above-average growth rate ranking at the 66th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which will improve affordability and make it easier for workers to relocate to the city. The increasing building permits are a positive sign for future workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Pittsburgh is 47 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.1%. This means that the housing market is relatively competitive, and homes are selling quickly. However, the decreasing days on market suggests that the market is still accessible for relocating workers, and businesses should not face significant challenges in attracting talent to the city.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's professional and office worker share is below average, ranking at the 36th percentile. This means that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool for tech, finance, and consulting businesses. However, the city may be well-suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of low unemployment, above-average wage growth, and expanding labor force supply. However, the city's above-average cost of living and relatively shallow office economy talent pool are significant considerations for businesses, particularly those in the tech and finance sectors. The biggest risk for businesses in Pittsburgh is the tight labor market, which may drive up labor costs and make it challenging to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #12 OF 50

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

A-

GOOD

59.4th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	94
Unemployment	20% weight	72
Wage Growth	15% weight	8
Cost of Living	12% weight	4
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	33
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	98
Days on Market	5% weight	86
Office Economy	3% weight	82

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.3%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.6%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+132.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	37 days	median, +8.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 59.4th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier percentile rank of 94th, and its extremely high cost of living, ranking at the 4th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an employment growth rate of +1.44% year-over-year and weekly hours deviation of +1.369% from its own trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a strong increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The top-tier percentile rank of 94th for labor demand composite score further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 4.00%, ranking at the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market implies that workers have more bargaining power, which can drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is +0.27%, ranking at the 8th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not increasing rapidly, but it also means that workers may have limited bargaining power and purchasing power. The low wage growth rate may make it challenging for businesses to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a cost of living percentile rank of 4th, indicating that it is an extremely expensive city relative to its peers. The PSF to earnings ratio is $813/sqft vs $53.33/hr, resulting in a ratio of 15.24, and the PSF is falling by -4.9% year-over-year. This high cost of living makes it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering significant wage premiums, as the cost of living is a major consideration for workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is growing at a rate of -0.60% year-over-year, ranking at the 33rd percentile, indicating a contracting labor pool. This decline in labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. The negative growth rate may limit the city's ability to support rapid business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has increased by +132.71% year-over-year, ranking at the 98th percentile, indicating a rapid expansion of housing supply. This surge in building permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and the future housing supply is likely to increase, which may improve affordability and support workforce growth.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.8%, ranking at the 86th percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. The rising days on market, however, may signal a healthy normalization of the market.

Office Economy

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 82nd, indicating a strong presence of tech, finance, and consulting jobs. This city is well-suited for businesses that require a highly skilled and specialized workforce, but may be less suitable for industries that rely on industrial or logistics workers.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for tech and finance companies. However, the extremely high cost of living and stagnant wage growth pose significant challenges for businesses looking to attract and retain talent, and these factors should be carefully considered in any location decision.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #13 OF 50

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

58.7th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	82
Unemployment	20% weight	22
Wage Growth	15% weight	66
Cost of Living	12% weight	78
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	84
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	20
Days on Market	5% weight	30
Office Economy	3% weight	92

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-17.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	70 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 58.7th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, and its deep professional talent pool, ranking at the 92nd percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.39% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.025% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 1.39% employment growth rate and a 0.025% increase in weekly hours above trend signals genuine demand expansion in the Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area. This indicates that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked also increasing, suggesting a strong and vibrant labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.27 further reinforces this assessment, placing it in the top tier at the 82nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford stands at 4.60%, which is below average, ranking at the 22nd percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that while it may be easier to find candidates, the market is not so loose as to depress wages significantly.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the metro area is 5.04%, which is above average, ranking at the 66th percentile. This rate of wage growth indicates a moderate to fast increase in labor costs for employers. For workers, this translates into stronger purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand but may pose challenges for businesses looking to keep labor costs in check.

Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is relatively affordable, with a cost of living percentile rank of 78th, indicating that it is more affordable than most of its peer cities. The PSF to earnings ratio is $224/sqft to $33.41/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.70. This affordability, combined with the fact that PSF is falling by 3.0% year-over-year, makes the city attractive for talent without necessitating significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area is growing at a rate of 1.74% year-over-year, which is in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This expansion in the labor force supply indicates that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, which is beneficial for businesses looking to hire and expand their operations. It suggests a positive outlook for hiring capacity in the area.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -17.79%, which ranks below average at the 20th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is not expanding as quickly as demand, potentially leading to future affordability issues and constraints on workforce accommodation. This could signal a tightening in the housing market, which may impact the city's ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 70 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%. This relatively fast market, ranking below average at the 30th percentile, indicates that homes are selling quickly. For a worker relocating to this city, the fast-paced housing market may make it challenging to find and secure a home, potentially affecting the decision to relocate.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is deep, with a percentile rank of 92nd. This suggests that the city has a strong talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations. The city is well-suited for knowledge-economy businesses but may be less ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

In conclusion, the Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers a business a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a relatively affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the decline in residential building permits, which may lead to future housing affordability issues and impact the city's attractiveness for relocating workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #14 OF 50

Memphis

Memphis

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

57.8th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	66
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	98
Cost of Living	12% weight	98
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	18
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	48
Days on Market	5% weight	16
Office Economy	3% weight	6

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+9.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-1.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	64 days	median, +10.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 57.8th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally high wage growth rate of 9.02% year-over-year and its top-tier cost of living affordability, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 4.61, driven by a 6.1% year-over-year decrease in PSF to $155/sqft. These metrics suggest a city with strong labor market dynamics and attractive affordability.

Labor Demand

Memphis exhibits a labor demand composite score of 5.65, ranking in the 66th percentile, driven by employment growth of 0.22% year-over-year and weekly hours 1.041% above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing. The scenario indicates a healthy labor market where businesses can find workers to meet growing demands.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis stands at 4.80%, ranking in the 36th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This rate suggests that while it may not be as challenging to hire as in tighter markets, there is still a notable pool of potential employees available. For a business trying to hire, this means a relatively easier staffing process compared to tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 9.02%, Memphis ranks in the 98th percentile, indicating very fast wage growth. This rapid increase in wages implies rising labor costs for employers but also signifies strong worker purchasing power. Businesses should anticipate higher compensation costs but also a workforce with increased disposable income.

Cost of Living

Memphis offers a highly affordable cost of living, ranking in the 98th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 4.61, driven by a decrease in PSF to $155/sqft. This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring wage premiums. The decreasing PSF relative to wages enhances this advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is contracting at a rate of -1.37% year-over-year, ranking in the 18th percentile. This contraction indicates a shrinking labor pool, presenting a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. Businesses should plan for potential recruitment challenges due to this declining labor force supply.

Building Permits

Memphis experienced a -1.49% year-over-year change in residential building permits, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This slight decrease in permits suggests a modest tightening in housing supply, which could impact future affordability and the ability to accommodate a growing workforce. However, the effect is not drastic, indicating a relatively stable housing market.

Days on Market

Homes in Memphis currently sit on the market for 64 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.3%, ranking in the 16th percentile. This indicates a slower market where homes take longer to sell, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. The rising days on market suggest a normalization of the housing market, potentially easing relocation challenges for new employees.

Office Economy

Memphis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the 6th percentile. This suggests the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different skill requirements, like logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses an attractive combination of high wage growth, very affordable cost of living, and a labor market with some slack, making it easier to hire. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the contracting labor force, which could pose significant challenges for recruitment and expansion plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #15 OF 50

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

57.4th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	96
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	58
Cost of Living	12% weight	55
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	51
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	0
Days on Market	5% weight	64
Office Economy	3% weight	86

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+2.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-39.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	55 days	median, +10.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 57.4th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a top-tier ranking of 96th percentile, driven by a 2.93% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.171% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. The combination of these metrics signals genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area boasts a 2.93% year-over-year employment growth rate, paired with a 0.171% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, indicating a strong and expanding labor market. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 8.57 further reinforces this assessment, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas stands at 5.20%, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that while it may be easier to find candidates, the local consumer demand might be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 4.53%, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. The wage growth is neither too fast to cause significant cost pressures nor too slow to indicate stagnant labor market conditions.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $264/sqft to $33.03/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 1.9% in PSF, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas ranks near the median in terms of affordability at the 55th percentile. This means the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without necessitating significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is growing at a rate of 0.22% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 51st percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is slowly expanding, which has a positive implication for hiring capacity, as businesses have a slightly increasing pool of potential employees to draw from.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -38.98%, ranking at the bottom tier. This significant decline signals that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The sharp drop in building permits is a concern for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.0%. This ranks above average at the 64th percentile, indicating a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For a worker relocating to this city, the housing market is relatively more accessible and less competitive compared to faster-moving markets.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is significant, with a composite score ranking at the 86th percentile. This deep talent pool makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions that require specialized knowledge-economy workers. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent acquisition and business growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which signals potential future challenges in housing affordability and workforce accommodation, potentially offsetting the city's current economic advantages.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #16 OF 50

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

B

AVERAGE

53.8th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	68
Unemployment	20% weight	72
Wage Growth	15% weight	12
Cost of Living	12% weight	24
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	90
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	68
Days on Market	5% weight	8
Office Economy	3% weight	50

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+2.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+14.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	39 days	median, -4.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 53.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and labor force growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.65, combining a +0.61% employment growth rate and a +0.496% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, its +2.00% labor force growth rate indicates an expanding workforce supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.61% and weekly hours deviation of +0.496% from its own trend suggest that Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is experiencing genuine demand expansion, with more jobs being added and hours worked above the trend. This combination indicates a healthy labor market where businesses can find the workers they need. The labor demand composite score of 5.65 further reinforces this assessment, placing the city in the 68th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.10% is relatively low, ranking in the 72nd percentile, which means the job market is tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as workers have more bargaining power, and wage pressure may be higher. However, it also suggests a skilled and employed workforce, which can be beneficial for businesses looking for qualified talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.68% is relatively slow, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weaker bargaining power for workers and potentially less purchasing power. For businesses, this could mean a more stable labor cost environment but may also indicate less consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 7.13, based on $232/sqft (which has decreased by 0.4% YoY) compared to $32.52/hr, Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington ranks in the 24th percentile for affordability. This means the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The decreasing PSF value is a positive sign, but the overall affordability remains a concern.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +2.00% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as more workers are available to fill positions. This can be particularly beneficial for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +14.19%, indicating that housing supply is expanding. This expansion signals improving affordability and a better ability to accommodate a growing workforce, which is crucial for attracting and retaining talent. The increase in building permits is a positive sign for the city's future housing market and workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 39 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.9%, ranking in the 8th percentile. This fast-paced market means that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, it also indicates a strong demand for housing in the area, which can be beneficial for the local economy.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 2.58, ranking near the median in the 50th percentile, Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a moderately deep professional talent pool. This makes the city suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but it may not be as competitive for industries requiring more specialized or industrial talent.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand and labor force growth, making it an attractive location for expansion or establishment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively expensive cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially offsetting the benefits of the city's other economic advantages.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #17 OF 50

Columbus

Columbus

B

AVERAGE

53.8th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	52
Unemployment	20% weight	96
Wage Growth	15% weight	48
Cost of Living	12% weight	43
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	37
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	10
Days on Market	5% weight	82
Office Economy	3% weight	16

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-25.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	39 days	median, +8.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B and a composite score ranking it at the 53.8th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 3.30% and a labor demand composite score of 5.16, which places it near the median. The city's economic character is also defined by its near-median employment growth rate of +0.44% and weekly hours deviation of +0.246%. These metrics suggest a stable, though not exceptionally strong, labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.44% and weekly hours deviation of +0.246% indicate a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination signals that the labor market is experiencing an increase in jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy demand for labor. The labor demand composite score of 5.16, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.30% ranks in the top tier at the 96th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in Columbus may face challenges in finding available workers, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have more bargaining power, making it a competitive market for talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.49% is near the median, ranking at the 48th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing, though not at an exceptional pace. The moderate wage growth may help attract and retain workers without significantly eroding profit margins.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 6.06, based on $208/sqft and $34.31/hr, and a percentile rank of 43, Columbus is near the median in terms of affordability. However, the PSF is increasing by 1.0% YoY, which may affect future affordability. The city's affordability, relative to its peers, means that it may not offer a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums, as the cost of living is not particularly low.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.43% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction suggests a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development to build the skills they need.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -25.53%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, indicating a significant tightening of housing supply. This sharp decline in building permits signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the housing stock is not expanding to meet potential demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of 8.3%, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This suggests a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to Columbus, this may mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market, allowing for more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 1.40, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, Columbus has a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This makes the city less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

In conclusion, Columbus offers a stable labor market with low unemployment, but also presents challenges such as a shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for a business considering locating in Columbus is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the competitive labor market and limited housing supply, which may require significant investment in wage premiums or training and development programs.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #18 OF 50

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

50.0th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	14
Unemployment	20% weight	60
Wage Growth	15% weight	54
Cost of Living	12% weight	80
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	74
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	44
Days on Market	5% weight	88
Office Economy	3% weight	22

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-2.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	36 days	median, +9.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of B- and ranks at the 50.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.78, indicating a struggling job market. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and high cost of living affordability, with a cost of living ratio of 5.92, which ranks in the 80th percentile, making it more affordable than most peers. The unemployment rate of 4.00% and wage growth of +3.93% also play significant roles in shaping the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate is -0.37% year-over-year, and weekly hours are -0.648% below the city's own trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with the city experiencing a decline in both jobs and hours worked. As a result, businesses may face a challenging environment for growth and expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate is 4.00%, ranking in the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. For businesses trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means they may face some competition for talent, but it is still possible to find qualified workers. However, the relatively low labor demand may limit the pool of available candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +3.93%, ranking in the 54th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a pace that is neither extremely high nor stagnant. As a result, workers in the city have moderate purchasing power, which can support local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The city has a cost of living ratio of 5.92, with a PSF of $219/sqft that is decreasing by -1.4% year-over-year, relative to hourly earnings of $36.97, ranking in the 80th percentile. This makes the city more affordable than most of its peers, which can be a significant advantage for talent attraction without requiring wage premiums. Businesses can leverage this affordability to attract and retain workers without incurring excessive labor costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.23% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city has a increasing pool of potential workers, which can support hiring capacity and business expansion. As a result, businesses may find it easier to find qualified candidates and grow their operations.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -2.81%, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that the city's housing market may become less affordable in the future, which can impact workforce accommodation and attraction. Businesses should consider the potential long-term implications of this trend on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +9.1%, ranking in the 88th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this trend may also signal a weakening demand for housing, which can have broader implications for the local economy.

Office Economy

The city has an office economy percentile rank of 22, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-oriented operations.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordability and moderate wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to balance labor costs and talent attraction. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's struggling labor demand, which may limit business growth and expansion opportunities.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #19 OF 50

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.7th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	50
Unemployment	20% weight	14
Wage Growth	15% weight	72
Cost of Living	12% weight	88
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	63
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	30
Days on Market	5% weight	30
Office Economy	3% weight	74

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.5%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-9.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	68 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 49.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 5.58% year-over-year and its relatively low unemployment rate of 4.70%, which signals a tight labor market. The cost of living, with a PSF of $238/sqft and a ratio of 6.38 to hourly earnings of $37.30, is also a key factor, ranking in the top tier for affordability at the 88th percentile.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 0.23% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of 0.504% above its own trend, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 5.13. This signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit at a moderate pace. The combination of these metrics suggests that the city is experiencing a steady, though not spectacular, increase in job opportunities.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.70%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, which means the labor market is relatively tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that it may need to invest more in recruitment and retention strategies.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 5.58%, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies that employer labor costs are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but they can also expect a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living ratio of 6.38, with a PSF of $238/sqft and hourly earnings of $37.30, ranking in the top tier for affordability at the 88th percentile. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The falling PSF, down 4.4% year-over-year, is a key driver of this high affordability score.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is growing at a rate of 0.52% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 63rd percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for businesses looking to hire. The implication for hiring capacity is that businesses can expect a steadily increasing pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is -9.95%, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation. This signals a potential risk for businesses relying on a mobile workforce or looking to attract talent from other areas.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 68 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the stable days on market suggests a balanced market, neither overly competitive nor excessively slow.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has an office economy percentile rank of 74th, indicating a deep professional talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors that rely on specialized knowledge workers. On the other hand, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, high wage growth, and relatively low cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint a decision-maker should factor in is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the decline in building permits, which may lead to future affordability challenges and impact workforce accommodation.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #20 OF 50

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.6th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	42
Unemployment	20% weight	64
Wage Growth	15% weight	84
Cost of Living	12% weight	18
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	14
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	80
Days on Market	5% weight	6
Office Economy	3% weight	58

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.6%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+19.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	37 days	median, -7.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 49.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth of 6.15% year-over-year and its low labor force growth rate of -1.59% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 0.60% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.223% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, with some genuine demand for jobs but not as strong as other metros. The labor demand composite score of 4.92 ranks near the median at the 42nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 4.20%, ranking at the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure due to the limited availability of workers. The tight market implies that employers may need to offer competitive salaries to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 6.15%, ranking at the 84th percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees can afford more goods and services with their increasing earnings. However, it also means that businesses will face higher labor costs, potentially affecting their bottom line.

Cost of Living

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a cost of living score ranking at the 18th percentile, with a PSF of $649/sqft and average hourly earnings of $50.11/hr, resulting in a ratio of 12.95. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The PSF has decreased by 4.1% year-over-year, but the city remains one of the more expensive metros.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has contracted by -1.59% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to consider alternative locations or strategies to attract talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has increased by 19.88% year-over-year, ranking at the 80th percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. As more housing units become available, the pressure on the existing stock may decrease, making it easier for workers to find affordable housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 7.5%. This indicates a competitive market where homes sell relatively quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The fast-paced market may require workers to act quickly when finding a home, potentially affecting their relocation decisions.

Office Economy

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a professional and office worker share ranking at the 58th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not be as attractive for industrial or logistics-dominant companies. The presence of a knowledgeable workforce can support businesses that require specialized skills and expertise.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a highly skilled and productive workforce, with strong wage growth and a deep professional talent pool. However, the biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the challenging labor market, characterized by low labor force growth and high labor costs, which may limit hiring capacity and increase expenses.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #21 OF 50

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.5th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	54
Unemployment	20% weight	58
Wage Growth	15% weight	94
Cost of Living	12% weight	12
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	20
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	12
Days on Market	5% weight	70
Office Economy	3% weight	70

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+7.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.3%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-23.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	43 days	median, +4.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 49.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 7.20% year-over-year and its low cost of living affordability score, ranking at the 12th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment with both opportunities and challenges for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 1.07% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.558% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, as the job market is growing, but hours worked are slightly below trend. This suggests that while there is some genuine demand for labor, it is not as strong as it could be.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 4.40%, ranking at the 58th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when trying to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 7.20%, ranking at the 94th percentile. This rapid wage growth signals a strong labor market with rising labor costs for employers. On the other hand, it also indicates good worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living score ranking at the 12th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $604/sqft to $43.09/hr, or 14.02. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. As a result, businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, which can be a competitive disadvantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is contracting at a rate of -1.30% year-over-year. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need. As a result, businesses may need to invest more in recruitment and training to attract and retain employees.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is declining at a rate of -23.29% year-over-year. This sharp decline in building permits signals a tightening housing supply, which can lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing. This may make it more difficult for businesses to attract and retain workers who are relocating to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.9%. This indicates a relatively slow market, ranking at the 70th percentile. As a result, workers relocating to this city may find it more accessible to find housing, which can be a competitive advantage for businesses.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a professional and office worker share ranking at the 70th percentile, with a composite score of 3.16. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, the city may be less suitable for businesses that require a large industrial or logistics workforce.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a relatively tight labor market. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low affordability and declining labor force supply, which can make it challenging to attract and retain talent without offering significant wage premiums.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #22 OF 50

Birmingham

Birmingham

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.4th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	74
Unemployment	20% weight	42
Wage Growth	15% weight	10
Cost of Living	12% weight	49
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	39
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	84
Days on Market	5% weight	30
Office Economy	3% weight	46

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.0%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.3%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+31.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	54 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.4th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 5.82, and its stagnant wage growth, at +0.59% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a growing job market but limited upward pressure on wages.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate is +0.97% year-over-year, combined with a +0.164% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong labor market. The above-average labor demand composite score of 74th percentile reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Birmingham is 3.70%, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This rate indicates a labor market with some slack, rather than being extremely tight. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding talent may be relatively easier compared to tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Birmingham is +0.59% year-over-year, placing it in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This stagnant wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are not rising quickly, but it also means that workers have limited bargaining power and purchasing power is not increasing rapidly.

Cost of Living

Birmingham has a cost of living score ranking near the median at the 49th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $160/sqft to $32.48/hr, or 4.93. The fact that PSF is falling by -1.8% year-over-year relative to wages suggests that the city is becoming more affordable. This affordability could attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is growing at a rate of -0.28% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 39th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies that the hiring capacity for businesses may be constrained, potentially leading to a more competitive market for talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +31.24%, placing Birmingham in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This significant increase in building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Birmingham is 54 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%. This stable and relatively fast market, ranking below average at the 30th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly. For a worker relocating to this city, the fast-paced housing market may present challenges in finding and securing a home.

Office Economy

Birmingham's professional and office worker share ranks near the median at the 46th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy but may not offer the same level of specialized talent as cities with a deeper professional sector.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers a growing job market with above-average labor demand and an expanding housing supply, which could support business growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the stagnant wage growth, which may limit the purchasing power of the local workforce and could impact the attractiveness of the city for certain types of businesses or talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #23 OF 50

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.6th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	56
Unemployment	20% weight	54
Wage Growth	15% weight	38
Cost of Living	12% weight	0
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	74
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	82
Days on Market	5% weight	12
Office Economy	3% weight	66

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+22.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	47 days	median, -4.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 48.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low cost of living percentile rank of 0th percentile, indicating an extremely high cost of living, and its above-average labor force growth rate of 1.23% YoY. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent without offering significant wage premiums.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is 0.68% YoY, with weekly hours deviating 0.000% from its own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.25, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as hours are not significantly above trend during job growth. The labor market is growing, but not at an exceptional rate.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 4.50%, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may not face extreme difficulty in hiring, but may still encounter some competition for top talent. The market is not overly tight, but it is also not loose enough to guarantee easy hiring.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in this metro area is 2.82%, ranking below average at the 38th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not exceptionally so. Employers should expect some upward pressure on wages, but it is not extreme.

Cost of Living

This city has a cost of living percentile rank of 0th percentile, with a PSF of $537/sqft and an earnings ratio of $40.52/hr, resulting in a ratio of 13.25. This indicates that the city is extremely expensive relative to peers, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering significant wage premiums. The high cost of living is a major constraint for businesses looking to locate in this area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is growing at a rate of 1.23% YoY, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This means that the workforce supply is expanding, providing businesses with a growing pool of potential employees. The implication is that hiring capacity is increasing, making it easier for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in this metro area is increasing by 22.60% YoY, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future. The increase in building permits is a positive signal for businesses concerned about the ability of their employees to find housing.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 47 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 4.1%. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The market is competitive, and businesses may need to provide relocation assistance to help their employees navigate the housing market.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is 3.08, ranking above average at the 66th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, the city may be less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses, which may not find the same level of specialized talent.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a growing labor force and an expanding housing supply, but it also presents significant challenges, particularly in terms of cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the extremely high cost of living, which will require businesses to offer significant wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #24 OF 50

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.6th percentile

Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	38
Unemployment	20% weight	20
Wage Growth	15% weight	88
Cost of Living	12% weight	39
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	26
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	94
Days on Market	5% weight	60
Office Economy	3% weight	72

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+91.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	37 days	median, +2.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 48.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.37%, and its high building permits growth, with a 91.03% year-over-year change. These metrics signal a city with a growing economy, but also with some challenges in terms of labor demand and cost of living.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 0.27% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by 0.048%. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, although at a slow pace. The labor demand composite score of 4.73 ranks below average at the 38th percentile, indicating that the city's job market is not as strong as others.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 5.00%, which is relatively high and ranks at the 20th percentile. This means that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 6.37%, which is a strong increase ranking at the 88th percentile. This fast wage growth means that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also gives workers more purchasing power. Businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a cost of living score that ranks at the 39th percentile, with a PSF of $444/sqft and average hourly earnings of $47.26/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.39. This means that the city is relatively expensive, which could make it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by 3.5% year-over-year is a positive sign, but the city still has a way to go in terms of affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is shrinking at a rate of -0.96% year-over-year, which ranks at the 26th percentile. This contraction in labor supply means that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire workers, making it a challenging location for companies that need to expand their workforce.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has increased by 91.03% year-over-year, ranking at the 94th percentile. This rapid growth in permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and make it easier for workers to relocate to the city. This is a positive sign for businesses that are concerned about their employees' ability to find housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.8%. This ranks at the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively slow market. For workers relocating to this city, this means that they may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, which could be a plus.

Office Economy

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking at the 72nd percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, it may not be the best fit for companies in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a strong economy with growing wages and an expanding housing supply, but it also comes with challenges such as a shrinking labor force and high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively expensive cost of living, which could make it harder to attract and retain talent without offering significant wage premiums.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #25 OF 50

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

47.5th percentile

Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	58
Unemployment	20% weight	62
Wage Growth	15% weight	28
Cost of Living	12% weight	65
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	6
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	26
Days on Market	5% weight	74
Office Economy	3% weight	56

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.9%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+2.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.6%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-2.1%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-14.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
48 days
median, +6.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 47.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, which is near median, and its cost of living, which is relatively affordable with a ratio of $286/sqft to $42.34/hr, ranking above average at the 65th percentile. The labor force growth and building permits metrics also stand out, but for negative reasons, with a labor force contraction of -2.15% YoY and a sharp decline in building permits of -14.11% YoY.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +0.60% YoY, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.147% from its own trend, signaling a genuine demand expansion. This indicates that jobs are being added and hours are running above trend, suggesting a healthy labor market. However, the labor demand composite score of 5.29 is only near median, ranking at the 58th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 3.90%, which is relatively low, ranking above average at the 62nd percentile. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +2.01%, which is below average, ranking at the 28th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. This may impact businesses' ability to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living ratio of $286/sqft to $42.34/hr, with a PSF decline of -3.7% YoY, making it relatively affordable, ranking above average at the 65th percentile. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is contracting at a rate of -2.15% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This structural headwind for hiring may pose challenges for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial has declined by -14.11% YoY, signaling a tightening housing supply. This decline may lead to future affordability issues and make it more difficult for the workforce to find accommodation, ultimately affecting the city's attractiveness to businesses and talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is currently 48 days, with a YoY increase of +6.7%, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it a more accessible market for relocating workers.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 2.86, ranking near median at the 56th percentile. This suggests a moderately deep talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but less ideal for those requiring a large industrial or logistics workforce.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a tight labor market, but also poses challenges due to a contracting labor force and declining building permits. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for future affordability issues and workforce accommodation challenges, which may impact the city's attractiveness to businesses and talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #26 OF 50

Cleveland

Cleveland

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

47.1th percentile

Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	36
Unemployment	20% weight	64
Wage Growth	15% weight	4
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	86
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	54
Days on Market	5% weight	58
Office Economy	3% weight	62

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
-0.3%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.6%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+1.8%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+0.6%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
55 days
median, +7.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it at the 47.1th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its below-average labor demand and stagnant wage growth, with a labor demand composite score of 4.66 and wage growth of -0.32% year-over-year. The city's economic character is also defined by its relatively low unemployment rate of 3.40% and its top-tier labor force growth of 1.80% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is 0.57% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.437% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a labor demand composite score that signals contraction rather than genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the city is not experiencing a significant increase in job openings or hours worked, which may indicate a slowdown in economic activity. The labor demand composite score of 4.66 ranks below average at the 36th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking above average at the 64th percentile, which means the market has some slack but is still relatively tight. This implies that businesses may face moderate competition for talent, but it is still possible to hire qualified workers without excessive wage pressure. However, the relatively low unemployment rate may still lead to some wage growth as businesses compete for the available labor pool.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cleveland is stagnant, with a year-over-year change of -0.32%, ranking at the bottom tier of the 4th percentile. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising quickly, but it also indicates weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant wage inflation, but workers may not have the disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Cleveland's cost of living, with a PSF of $143/sqft and average hourly earnings of $33.82/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.23, ranks near the median at the 50th percentile. This means that the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The cost of living is not a significant advantage or disadvantage for talent attraction, as the city's affordability is average, and businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of 1.80% year-over-year, ranking at the top tier of the 86th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers. The increasing labor force can help meet hiring demands and reduce the risk of labor shortages.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Cleveland is increasing by 0.56% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This moderate growth in building permits suggests that housing supply is slowly expanding, which can help improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the relatively slow growth rate may not be enough to keep up with demand, potentially leading to some affordability challenges in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Cleveland is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.8%, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This means that the housing market is relatively balanced, neither extremely competitive nor extremely slow. For workers relocating to the city, this suggests a moderately accessible housing market, but businesses may still need to consider housing costs and availability when recruiting talent.

Office Economy

Cleveland's professional and office worker share is 3.04, ranking above average at the 62nd percentile, indicating a relatively deep talent pool in these sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors that rely on specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers businesses a mixed economic environment with both advantages and challenges. The city's top-tier labor force growth and relatively low unemployment rate are positives, but the stagnant wage growth and below-average labor demand are concerns. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for labor market tightening and upward wage pressure if the economy accelerates, making it essential to monitor labor market trends closely.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #27 OF 50

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.2th percentile

Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	78
Unemployment	20% weight	14
Wage Growth	15% weight	26
Cost of Living	12% weight	69
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	50
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	14
Days on Market	5% weight	52
Office Economy	3% weight	90

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	N/A	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-22.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	51 days	median, +2.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 46.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 78th percentile, and its high cost of living affordability, ranked in the 69th percentile. Specifically, the city's employment growth rate of 1.27% and weekly hours deviation of 0.162% above its own trend signal genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.27% and weekly hours deviation of 0.162% above its own trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.24, ranking in the 78th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.70% is relatively high, ranking in the 14th percentile, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate. As a result, companies may not face intense wage pressure, but they may also not benefit from a strongly growing local market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 1.95% is below average, ranking in the 26th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but workers may not have strong bargaining power either.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of $202/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.13/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.44, is relatively affordable, ranking in the 69th percentile. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live and work in the area without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.4% YoY further enhances the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force growth rate is not available, but it is ranked near the median at the 50th percentile. This suggests that the workforce supply is neither expanding nor contracting significantly, which may have a neutral impact on hiring capacity. However, without the exact growth rate, it is difficult to assess the implications for businesses.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -22.31%, ranking in the 14th percentile, indicating a significant tightening of housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. As a result, businesses may face challenges in attracting and retaining workers due to limited housing options.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.0%, ranking in the 52nd percentile. This suggests that the housing market is relatively balanced, neither extremely competitive nor extremely accessible. Workers relocating to this city may find a moderate pace of home sales, which could impact their decision to move to the area.

Office Economy

The city has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 4.06, ranking in the 90th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may impact future affordability and workforce accommodation, making it essential for businesses to factor this into their location decisions.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #28 OF 50

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

45.6th percentile

Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	34
Unemployment	20% weight	24
Wage Growth	15% weight	68
Cost of Living	12% weight	82
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	45
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	38
Days on Market	5% weight	80
Office Economy	3% weight	2

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-6.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	51 days	median, +13.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 45.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 4.39, and its high cost of living affordability, ranking in the 82nd percentile. Specifically, the labor demand metrics, including employment growth and weekly hours, and the cost of living, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $172/sqft to $33.58/hr, are key to understanding this city's economy.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is +0.15% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.117% below trend, indicating a labor demand contraction. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not increasing alongside job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.39 is below average, ranking in the 34th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 4.20%, which is below average, ranking in the 24th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. The practical implication is that businesses may face some competition for talent, but it's not extremely difficult to find workers.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Oklahoma City is +5.07% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking in the 68th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing worker purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but workers will have more disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

Oklahoma City is relatively affordable, with a cost of living ranking in the 82nd percentile. The PSF to earnings ratio is $172/sqft to $33.58/hr, with PSF decreasing by -0.6% year-over-year. This affordability advantage means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is growing at a rate of -0.04% year-over-year, which is near the median, ranking in the 45th percentile. This indicates a slightly contracting labor force supply, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring in the future. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Oklahoma City is decreasing by -6.14% year-over-year, which is below average, ranking in the 38th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact on their ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Oklahoma City is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of +13.3%, ranking in the 80th percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this also suggests that the market may be normalizing after a period of rapid growth, which could have implications for future housing affordability.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the 2nd percentile. This makes it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-oriented economies.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a growing wage base, but its labor demand and labor force growth metrics are concerning. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential tightening of the housing market, which could lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation, making it essential to carefully consider the city's overall economic character and potential implications for business operations.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #29 OF 50

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

45.5th percentile

Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	76
Unemployment	20% weight	42
Wage Growth	15% weight	50
Cost of Living	12% weight	6
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	4
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	46
Days on Market	5% weight	68
Office Economy	3% weight	48

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.8%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-2.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-2.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	50 days	median, +6.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score in the 76th percentile, and its cost of living, which ranks in the 6th percentile, indicating a relatively expensive environment. The labor demand and cost of living metrics are crucial in understanding the city's economic landscape, with employment growth at 1.83% and weekly hours 0.906% below trend.

Labor Demand

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an employment growth rate of 1.83% and weekly hours 0.906% below trend, signaling a genuine demand expansion despite the slight dip in hours worked. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs, albeit with a minor adjustment in working hours. The labor demand composite score of 5.96 further supports this notion, placing it in the 76th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim stands at 5.00%, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This rate suggests a relatively balanced market, neither too tight nor too slack. For businesses trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate implies a manageable but not overly competitive hiring environment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 3.57%, placing it near the median at the 50th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate indicates a stable labor cost environment for employers, while also providing workers with some, though not exceptional, purchasing power increases.

Cost of Living

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim has a cost of living score in the 6th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $662/sqft to $41.35/hr, equating to 16.01. This low percentile rank signifies that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The falling PSF value (-2.5% YoY) slightly mitigates this, but overall, the high cost of living poses a challenge for talent attraction without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim has contracted by 2.24% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This negative growth rate presents a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing.

Building Permits

The city has seen a 2.43% year-over-year decrease in residential building permits. This decline suggests that the housing supply is not expanding at a pace that keeps up with demand, potentially leading to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim currently sit on the market for a median of 50 days, with a 6.4% year-over-year increase. This increase in days on market, ranking in the 68th percentile, indicates a slightly slower and more accessible market for relocating workers, providing them with more time to find suitable housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office sector jobs in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim places it in the 48th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is suited for businesses that can leverage its professional workforce, particularly in sectors like tech, finance, and consulting, but may not be ideal for industries requiring a large industrial or logistics workforce.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers a business a moderate economic environment with genuine labor demand expansion, but it comes with the significant challenge of a high and rising cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the expensive housing market and the shrinking labor force, which could impact both talent attraction and future hiring capacity.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #30 OF 50

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

45.1th percentile

Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	18
Unemployment	20% weight	34
Wage Growth	15% weight	44
Cost of Living	12% weight	14
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	98
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	92
Days on Market	5% weight	98
Office Economy	3% weight	52

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.4%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+2.9%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+67.5%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **37 days** median, +19.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor force growth of 2.87% YoY and its high cost of living, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 10.68. The labor demand composite score of 3.82, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, also plays a significant role in shaping the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 0.39% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -1.026% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The negative hours deviation suggests that the modest employment growth may be due to a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, ranking in the below-average tier at the 34th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means that hiring may be moderately challenging, but not extremely difficult, with some wage pressure likely.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.21%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly. Workers in the city are experiencing a moderate increase in purchasing power, which is a positive factor for local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living percentile rank of 14, indicating that it is an expensive city relative to its peers. The PSF to earnings ratio of 10.68, with PSF at $486/sqft, suggests that the city is not very affordable. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums may be challenging, as the high cost of living may deter some workers from relocating to the city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of 2.87% YoY, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This rapid expansion of the labor force supply means that hiring capacity is strong, and businesses can tap into a growing pool of workers. The city's ability to attract and retain workers is a significant advantage for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton has increased by 67.46% YoY, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This surge in building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate the growing workforce. The increase in permits suggests that developers are confident in the city's future growth prospects.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of 19.4%. This ranks in the top tier at the 98th percentile, indicating a slower market. For a worker relocating to this city, the slower market means that they may have more time to find a home, making the city more accessible to newcomers.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 2.78, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool, suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, the city may not be as well-suited for industries that require a large number of industrial or logistics workers.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor force growth and a moderately deep professional talent pool. However, the city's high cost of living and moderate wage growth rate may pose challenges for businesses looking to attract and retain talent without offering significant wage premiums. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for hiring difficulties and wage pressure due to the city's tight labor market and high cost of living.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #31 OF 50

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.7th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	0
Unemployment	20% weight	52
Wage Growth	15% weight	70
Cost of Living	12% weight	74
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	10
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	90
Days on Market	5% weight	78
Office Economy	3% weight	34

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-2.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+53.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	36 days	median, +5.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 44.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 1.50, and its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.20%. The combination of a -2.44% employment growth rate and a -0.870% weekly hours deviation from trend suggests a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -2.44% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.870% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and a decrease in working hours. This suggests that businesses may not face strong competition for labor, but it also indicates a slower economy.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 4.10%, ranking it near the median at the 52nd percentile. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also means that businesses may still face some competition for top talent, and wages may be subject to upward pressure.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 5.20% year-over-year, ranking it above average at the 70th percentile. This fast wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also indicates that workers have strong purchasing power. Businesses should be prepared to offer competitive salaries to attract and retain top talent in this market.

Cost of Living

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living score ranking it above average at the 74th percentile, with a PSF of $308/sqft and average hourly earnings of $45.00/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.84. The PSF is also falling by -2.2% year-over-year, making the city more affordable relative to peers. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is contracting at a rate of -1.70% year-over-year, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This decline in labor force supply suggests that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire workers, as the pool of available labor is shrinking.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is increasing by 53.15% year-over-year, ranking it in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This rapid expansion in housing supply suggests that the city is likely to experience improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for workforce growth in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.9%. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find homes. However, the relatively fast days on market still indicates a competitive market.

Office Economy

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a professional and office worker share ranking it below average at the 34th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent attraction. However, the city's weak labor demand and contracting labor force supply pose significant risks for businesses looking to hire and expand in this market, and decision-makers should carefully consider these constraints when evaluating this location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #32 OF 50

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

C+

POOR

43.4th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	16
Unemployment	20% weight	68
Wage Growth	15% weight	24
Cost of Living	12% weight	20
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	80
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	64
Days on Market	5% weight	92
Office Economy	3% weight	28

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+9.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	33 days	median, +13.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its relatively low cost of living, ranked in the 20th percentile. The labor demand is particularly noteworthy, with employment growth and weekly hours both below trend, signaling a contraction in the job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.36% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.511% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in the job market, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The low labor demand composite score of 3.80, ranked in the bottom tier, further reinforces this signal.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.80%, which is relatively low and corresponds to an above-average percentile rank of 68th. This indicates a tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when trying to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +1.56%, which is below average and ranked in the 24th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit gradually. This may be beneficial for businesses looking to manage labor costs.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living ranked in the 20th percentile, with a PSF of $230/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.18/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.36. Although the PSF is increasing by 2.2% year-over-year, the city remains relatively expensive compared to its peers. This may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of +1.66% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the hiring capacity in the city is increasing, which could be beneficial for businesses looking to expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha is increasing by +9.94% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve, making the city more attractive to relocating workers and businesses.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Milwaukee-Waukesha is currently 33 days, with a year-over-year increase of +13.8%, corresponding to a top-tier percentile rank of 92nd. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for workers to relocate to the city.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Milwaukee-Waukesha is ranked in the 28th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers businesses a relatively low-cost environment and an expanding workforce supply, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the low labor demand, which may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth. Decision-makers should carefully consider this factor when evaluating the city as a potential location for their business. Overall, the city's economic character is defined by its unique combination of low labor demand and relatively low cost of living, making it an attractive option for businesses that prioritize affordability and accessibility.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #33 OF 50

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

C+

POOR

41.4th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	8
Unemployment	20% weight	50
Wage Growth	15% weight	78
Cost of Living	12% weight	37
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	22
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	96
Days on Market	5% weight	18
Office Economy	3% weight	18

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+106.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	37 days	median, -2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 41.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 3.01, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, and its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.91% in hourly earnings, ranking it above average at the 78th percentile. These metrics suggest a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is -0.55% year-over-year, and weekly hours are running 0.523% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This is a challenging sign for businesses looking to hire and expand in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 4.00%, which ranks it near the median at the 50th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant slack nor tightness. For a business trying to hire, this means that while it may not be extremely difficult to find workers, it also won't be particularly easy, and wage pressure may be moderate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in this metro area is 5.91%, which is significantly above average, ranking it at the 78th percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also strong worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for increasing labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $224/sqft to $35.28/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.35, and a year-over-year increase of 2.3% in PSF, this city ranks below average at the 37th percentile in terms of affordability. This means the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is shrinking at a rate of -1.05% year-over-year, ranking it below average at the 22nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find the workers they need.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +106.92%, ranking it in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This significant increase in building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth in the future.

Days on Market

Homes in this metro area are currently selling at a median of 37 days on market, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.6%. This fast market makes it competitive for workers relocating to the area, as homes are selling quickly, indicating a hot market that may favor sellers over buyers.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in this metro area is relatively low, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This suggests a less deep talent pool for businesses requiring specialized professional or office workers, making it less suited for tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions, but potentially more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers a complex mix of strong wage growth and challenging labor market conditions. The single biggest risk or constraint for a business considering this location is the shrinking labor force and the relatively expensive cost of living, which could make it difficult to attract and retain talent without significant wage premiums.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #34 OF 50

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

C+

POOR

41.3th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	60
Unemployment	20% weight	6
Wage Growth	15% weight	22
Cost of Living	12% weight	53
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	69
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	24
Days on Market	5% weight	76
Office Economy	3% weight	78

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-14.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	50 days	median, +8.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 41.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score in the 60th percentile, and its high unemployment rate, which stands at 5.20% and ranks in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment with both positive and negative trends.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is +1.14% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.342%, both of which contribute to a labor demand composite score in the 60th percentile. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs and hours are running above trend. However, the negative deviation in weekly hours may indicate some degree of inefficiency in labor utilization.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 5.20%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This indicates a slack labor market with relatively high unemployment, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is +1.52%, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. As a result, worker purchasing power is increasing, but not as rapidly as in cities with faster wage growth.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $172/sqft to $36.01/hr, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a near-median affordability score, ranking in the 53rd percentile. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage for businesses that do not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is growing at a rate of +0.88% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 69th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire workers. As the labor force grows, the city's hiring capacity is increasing, making it easier for companies to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has decreased by -14.66% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 24th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This may pose a risk to workforce accommodation and attraction in the long term.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is currently 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.7%, ranking in the 76th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to this city, this means a more accessible and less competitive housing market, which could be an advantage for businesses looking to attract talent.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 3.28, ranking in the 78th percentile, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area offers businesses a complex economic environment with both opportunities and challenges. While the city's labor demand and expanding labor force are positive signs, the high unemployment rate and tightening housing supply pose significant risks. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the potential for decreased affordability and increased competition for housing, which could impact workforce attraction and accommodation in the long term.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #35 OF 50

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

C+

POOR

41.3th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	28
Unemployment	20% weight	46
Wage Growth	15% weight	92
Cost of Living	12% weight	26
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	41
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	4
Days on Market	5% weight	28
Office Economy	3% weight	76

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-30.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	82 days	median, -1.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 41.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.93%, and its struggling labor demand, with a composite score of 4.29, ranking below average at the 28th percentile. These metrics signal a complex economic environment, with rising labor costs and a relatively weak job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 0.18% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.262% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, as hours are below trend despite modest job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.29, ranking at the 28th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.90%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This indicates a labor market with some slack, rather than being extremely tight. For a business trying to hire in this city, the relatively moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding talent may be manageable, but not overly challenging.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 6.93%, ranking at the 92nd percentile. This rapid wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but also strong purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor expenses, while also benefiting from a local workforce with increased disposable income.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score ranking at the 26th percentile, with a PSF of $357/sqft and average hourly earnings of $34.40/hr, resulting in a ratio of 10.38. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling -1.1% year-over-year is a positive sign, but overall, the city's affordability is a challenge, making it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of -0.14% year-over-year. This contraction in labor force supply signals a potential structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to compensate for this declining labor force.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is -30.46%, ranking at the 4th percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation. As a result, businesses may face increased competition for talent due to limited housing options.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 82 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.2%. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the slight decrease in days on market suggests some normalization in the market.

Office Economy

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has an office economy score ranking at the 76th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations, but less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a deep professional talent pool, but also poses significant challenges due to its expensive cost of living and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for affordability and housing challenges to limit the city's attractiveness to talent, ultimately impacting businesses' ability to hire and retain workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #36 OF 50

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

C+

POOR

40.0th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	80
Unemployment	20% weight	10
Wage Growth	15% weight	34
Cost of Living	12% weight	51
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	2
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	18
Days on Market	5% weight	46
Office Economy	3% weight	84

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.9%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+2.4%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.4%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-2.7%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-19.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **64 days** median, -1.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 40.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier ranking of 80th percentile, and its low unemployment rate of 4.90%, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. The combination of these two metrics suggests a highly competitive job market with strong demand for labor.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +1.37% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.048%, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked above the trend, suggesting that businesses are expanding their operations and hiring more workers. The labor demand composite score of 6.27 further reinforces this notion, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 4.90%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that there is significant competition for workers, making it challenging for businesses to hire and retain talent. As a result, businesses may need to offer higher wages or more attractive benefits to attract and retain employees.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +2.39%, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. While this may be beneficial for workers' purchasing power, it also means that businesses may need to balance their labor costs with revenue growth to maintain profitability.

Cost of Living

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a cost of living score ranking at the 51st percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $269/sqft to $37.40/hr, or 7.19. The fact that the price per square foot is falling by -1.8% year-over-year relative to wages suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. This affordability can be a significant advantage for talent attraction, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is contracting at a rate of -2.70% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply suggests that the city may face structural headwinds in hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and retain talent. As a result, businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to upskill existing workers or attract workers from other areas.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is decreasing by -19.67% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to increased competition for housing and higher prices. This could negatively impact future affordability and workforce accommodation, making it more challenging for businesses to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 64 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.5%. This relatively fast pace of home sales suggests that the housing market is competitive, making it challenging for relocating workers to find and purchase homes. However, the fact that the days on market are decreasing may indicate a normalization of the market, rather than a significant erosion of demand.

Office Economy

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which require a different type of workforce.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the city's low unemployment rate and declining labor force supply pose significant risks and constraints for businesses, particularly in terms of hiring and retaining talent. As a result, decision-makers should carefully consider these factors when evaluating the city as a potential location for their business.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #37 OF 50

Providence

Providence-Warwick

C

VERY POOR

37.6th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	46
Unemployment	20% weight	28
Wage Growth	15% weight	40
Cost of Living	12% weight	2
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	82
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	34
Days on Market	5% weight	14
Office Economy	3% weight	68

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-8.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	32 days	median, +3.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 37.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 5.11. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.30% and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.15. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is 0.60% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.025% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, with some genuine demand for jobs but not excessively high. The near-median percentile rank of 46th suggests a stable but not exceptional labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, which is below average, ranking 28th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire here. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when competing for talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Providence-Warwick is 3.00%, which is near median, ranking 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. This balance may attract businesses looking for a stable labor environment.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living percentile rank of 2, indicating that it is one of the most expensive cities relative to peers, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.15 and a PSF increase of 8.9% year-over-year. This means that the city is at a significant disadvantage for talent attraction, as businesses may need to offer wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of 1.69% year-over-year, ranking 82nd percentile. This suggests that the labor force supply is expanding, providing businesses with a growing pool of potential employees and a positive implication for hiring capacity.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Providence-Warwick has decreased by 8.13% year-over-year, ranking 34th percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges for workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Providence-Warwick is 32 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.2%, ranking 14th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city, but also suggesting some demand erosion.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy percentile rank of 68, indicating a deep professional talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Providence-Warwick offers businesses a stable labor market with moderate wage growth, but its high cost of living and tightening housing supply are significant concerns. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's expensive cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #38 OF 50

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

C

VERY POOR

36.9th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	64
Unemployment	20% weight	30
Wage Growth	15% weight	6
Cost of Living	12% weight	29
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	24
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	62
Days on Market	5% weight	30
Office Economy	3% weight	14

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+9.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	37 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 5.63 and an unemployment rate of 4.40%. The city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, driven by a 1.46% employment growth rate, and its stagnant wage growth, with a year-over-year change of only 0.01%. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with some positive trends but also significant challenges.

Labor Demand

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an employment growth rate of 1.46% and a weekly hours deviation of -0.718% from its own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.63, which ranks in the 64th percentile. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs and hours are running above trend. However, the negative hours deviation suggests some inefficiencies in the labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area is 4.40%, which ranks in the 30th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. With an unemployment rate above the national average, companies may have a larger pool of potential employees to draw from.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area is 0.01%, ranking in the 6th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but may also struggle to attract top talent.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in the Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area is relatively high, with a PSF of $212/sqft and an earnings ratio of 5.37, ranking in the 29th percentile. However, the PSF is falling by 0.5% year-over-year, which is a positive trend. This means that the city is less affordable than many of its peers, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in the Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area is contracting, with a year-over-year growth rate of -0.97%, ranking in the 24th percentile. This means that the supply of workers is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and potentially limiting the city's ability to support business growth.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in the Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area is increasing, with a year-over-year change of 9.15%, ranking in the 62nd percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and make it easier for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area is 37 days, with no year-over-year change. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the stable days on market suggests that the market is not becoming more competitive.

Office Economy

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the 14th percentile. This means that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep pool of office-based talent, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses with industrial or logistics-oriented operations.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers businesses a mixed economic environment, with some positive trends in labor demand and building permits, but also significant challenges in terms of stagnant wage growth and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the limited supply of workers, which could limit their ability to grow and expand operations.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #39 OF 50

Fresno

Fresno

C

VERY POOR

36.8th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	44
Unemployment	20% weight	0
Wage Growth	15% weight	80
Cost of Living	12% weight	45
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	12
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	36
Days on Market	5% weight	54
Office Economy	3% weight	30

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	7.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-6.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	55 days	median, +5.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Fresno has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 5.04. The city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 5.96% and its low unemployment rate of 7.70%, which indicates a tight labor market. However, the labor force growth rate of -1.69% suggests a shrinking labor pool, which could pose a challenge for businesses looking to hire.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is 1.60% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -2.051% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, but the decrease in weekly hours suggests that the growth may not be entirely driven by genuine demand. The labor demand composite score of 5.04 is near the median, indicating a stable but not exceptional labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 7.70%, which is the lowest percentile rank, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and wage pressure may be high. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Fresno is 5.96%, which is in the top tier, ranking 80th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have strong purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local businesses. However, the high wage growth may also lead to increased costs for companies operating in the area.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living ratio of 7.82, with a PSF of $263/sqft and average hourly earnings of $33.62/hr, ranking near the median at 45th percentile. This indicates that the city is neither extremely affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The stable PSF growth rate of 0.0% year-over-year suggests that the cost of living is not increasing rapidly, making it moderately attractive for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is shrinking at a rate of -1.69% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This decline in labor force growth poses a significant challenge for businesses looking to hire, as it may lead to a shortage of skilled workers and increased competition for available talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Fresno has decreased by 6.89% year-over-year, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in building permits may lead to a supply squeeze, making it more difficult for workers to find affordable housing, which could negatively impact the city's attractiveness to businesses and talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Fresno is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.8%. This suggests a moderately competitive housing market, which may make it accessible for relocating workers to find homes. However, the rising days on market may also indicate a normalization of the market, rather than a significant slowdown.

Office Economy

Fresno's professional and office worker share is below average, ranking 30th percentile, with a composite score of 1.86. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more attractive to industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Fresno offers a unique combination of high wage growth and a tight labor market, making it an attractive location for businesses that can adapt to these conditions. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the shrinking labor pool, which may lead to significant challenges in hiring and retaining talent, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully consider this factor when evaluating Fresno as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #40 OF 50

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

C

VERY POOR

36.4th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	24
Unemployment	20% weight	32
Wage Growth	15% weight	86
Cost of Living	12% weight	41
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	8
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	32
Days on Market	5% weight	44
Office Economy	3% weight	0

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-9.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	59 days	median, +1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score defined largely by its below-average labor demand and strong wage growth, at +0.65% employment growth and +6.17% year-over-year wage growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.00 and unemployment rate of 5.30% are key metrics that characterize this city's economic landscape. These numbers indicate a mixed economic environment, with both positive and negative trends.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.65% and weekly hours deviation of -1.215% from the city's own trend signal a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, as hours are below trend despite job growth. This combination suggests that the labor market is not as strong as the employment growth rate might indicate. The labor demand composite score of 4.00, ranking in the 24th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 5.30% ranks in the 32nd percentile, indicating a labor market with some slack, rather than being extremely tight. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may have a relatively easier time finding candidates, but may not face intense competition for talent. However, the unemployment rate is not low enough to indicate a highly favorable hiring environment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +6.17% is strong, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This rapid wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, but may pose challenges for businesses looking to keep labor costs under control. As a result, employers may need to budget for higher wage expenses in this city.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario, with a PSF of $335/sqft and average hourly earnings of $35.56, resulting in a ratio of 9.42, ranks in the 41st percentile, indicating a near-median affordability level. The fact that PSF is falling by -2.3% year-over-year is a positive sign for affordability. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor extremely expensive, and businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -1.87% year-over-year, ranking in the 8th percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential employees is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified candidates in this environment.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -9.60%, ranking in the 32nd percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that the city's housing stock may not be expanding quickly enough to accommodate a growing workforce, which could lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 59 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.7%, ranking in the 44th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, where homes are sitting on the market for a moderate amount of time. For workers relocating to this city, this may mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 0.22, ranking in the 0th percentile, indicating a very shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is not well-suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. Instead, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers a mixed economic environment, with strong wage growth but below-average labor demand and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the tightening housing supply and potential future affordability challenges, which could impact their ability to attract and retain talent. Overall, businesses should carefully weigh the pros and cons of this location, considering both the benefits of strong wage growth and the challenges posed by a shrinking labor pool and limited housing supply.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #41 OF 50

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

C

VERY POOR

35.8th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	0
Unemployment	20% weight	24
Wage Growth	15% weight	76
Cost of Living	12% weight	67
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	29
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	56
Days on Market	5% weight	56
Office Economy	3% weight	8

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **5.0%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.8%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-2.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.8%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+2.5%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **51 days** median, +4.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its weak labor demand and high wage growth. The labor demand composite score of 1.50, combining a -2.07% employment growth rate and a -0.245% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in labor demand. This, coupled with a wage growth rate of +5.82%, suggests that while workers are seeing significant wage increases, the overall job market is not expanding.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -2.07% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.245% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a clear contraction in labor demand. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a reduction in job openings rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The labor demand composite score of 1.50 falls into the bottom tier, at the 0th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro stands at 5.00%, placing it at the 24th percentile, which is below average. This rate indicates that the job market has some slack, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, it's not so high as to suggest significant weakness in local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.82%, Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is experiencing above-average wage increases, ranking at the 76th percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also means workers have stronger purchasing power. Businesses should factor in these increasing labor costs when considering relocation or expansion.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score that places it at the 67th percentile, indicating it is more affordable than many of its peers, with a PSF of $309/sqft and average hourly earnings of $42.08/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.34. The fact that PSF is decreasing by -1.9% year-over-year contributes to its relative affordability. This makes the city attractive for talent without necessitating significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is shrinking at a rate of -0.81% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in the labor supply. This negative growth rate suggests that the workforce is not expanding, which could pose a structural headwind for businesses looking to hire in the area.

Building Permits

The city is seeing a +2.48% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, which signals a modest expansion in future housing supply. This growth, ranking at the 56th percentile, suggests that developer confidence is present, and affordability might improve over time, supporting workforce accommodation and attraction.

Days on Market

Homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro are currently sitting on the market for 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of +4.1%. This indicates a slightly slower market, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. For workers relocating to this city, the market is somewhat more accessible than extremely competitive markets, but it's not overly buyer-friendly.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 0.68, ranking at the 8th percentile, Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This makes the city less suited for businesses requiring deep tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations talent but might be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers a unique blend of affordability and wage growth, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses, especially those not heavily reliant on a deep professional services talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's weak labor demand and contracting labor force, which could significantly impact hiring capacity and business expansion plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #42 OF 50

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

C

VERY POOR

35.7th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	32
Unemployment	20% weight	18
Wage Growth	15% weight	2
Cost of Living	12% weight	59
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	67
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	70
Days on Market	5% weight	26
Office Economy	3% weight	54

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-0.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+15.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	59 days	median, -11.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score defined largely by its low labor demand and high unemployment rate, at 4.80%. The labor demand composite score of 4.39 and unemployment rate of 4.80% suggest a challenging economic environment. Specifically, the combination of low employment growth and high unemployment indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Jacksonville is +0.33% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.372% below the city's own trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine expansion. This combination indicates that the city is not experiencing a significant increase in jobs, and the hours worked are also below the average trend. The labor demand composite score of 4.39 is below average, ranking 32nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.80%, which is relatively high, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the high unemployment rate also implies weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Jacksonville is -0.68%, indicating stagnant or even declining wages. This slow wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that workers have weak bargaining power and limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score with a PSF of $217/sqft, which is decreasing by -2.7% year-over-year, compared to average hourly earnings of $36.43/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.96. With a percentile rank of 59th, the city is near the median in terms of affordability, suggesting that it is neither particularly expensive nor exceptionally affordable. This means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is growing at a rate of +0.78% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, which can be beneficial for businesses looking to hire.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Jacksonville is increasing by +15.03% year-over-year, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This rise in building permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and the future housing supply is likely to improve, which can lead to better affordability and workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Jacksonville is 59 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -11.9%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking in the 26th percentile, indicates a competitive market for relocating workers, making it challenging for them to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

Jacksonville has an office economy score with a professional worker share of 2.86, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it suitable for businesses in tech, finance, or consulting, but less ideal for those requiring a highly specialized knowledge economy workforce.

The city of Jacksonville offers businesses a mix of advantages and challenges, with an expanding labor force and increasing housing supply being notable positives. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and high unemployment rate, which may limit the growth potential of businesses and affect local consumer demand. Overall, businesses should carefully weigh these factors when considering Jacksonville as a location for their operations.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #43 OF 50

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

C

VERY POOR

34.9th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	12
Unemployment	20% weight	12
Wage Growth	15% weight	20
Cost of Living	12% weight	94
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	55
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	58
Days on Market	5% weight	42
Office Economy	3% weight	60

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.8%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+1.3%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.6%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+0.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+5.8%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
61 days
median, -1.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.65. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and high affordability, with a cost of living ratio of $173/sqft to $32.51/hr, resulting in a top-tier percentile rank of 94th. The combination of low employment growth and below-average wage growth also contributes to its economic profile.

Labor Demand

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an employment growth rate of +0.61% and a weekly hours deviation of -2.350% from its own trend, indicating a labor demand contraction. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are below trend despite modest job growth. The labor demand composite score of 3.65 falls in the bottom tier, at the 12th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 4.80%, which is relatively high, resulting in a bottom-tier percentile rank. This indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the relatively high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Antonio-New Braunfels is +1.33%, which is below average, ranking at the 20th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies relatively stable labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have limited bargaining power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages.

Cost of Living

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a cost of living ratio of $173/sqft to $32.51/hr, with the price per square foot falling by 5.0% year-over-year. This results in a top-tier percentile rank of 94th, indicating that the city is highly affordable relative to its peers. The falling price per square foot is a key driver of this high affordability score, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Antonio-New Braunfels is growing at a rate of +0.23% year-over-year, which is near the median, ranking at the 55th percentile. This slow growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, but at a modest pace. As a result, businesses may face some challenges in finding skilled workers, but the labor pool is not shrinking.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Antonio-New Braunfels is increasing by +5.83% year-over-year, which is near the median, ranking at the 58th percentile. This growth in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 61 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.6%. This indicates a relatively competitive market, but still accessible for workers relocating to the city. The near-median percentile rank of 42nd suggests that the market is not overly hot or cold.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 2.98, resulting in an above-average percentile rank of 60th. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, the city may be less suitable for industries with limited office-based roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high affordability and a growing labor force, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand, which may limit the availability of skilled workers and hinder business growth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #44 OF 50

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

C

VERY POOR

34.8th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	4
Unemployment	20% weight	86
Wage Growth	15% weight	0
Cost of Living	12% weight	10
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	51
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	52
Days on Market	5% weight	90
Office Economy	3% weight	18

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-0.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-1.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-0.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	45 days	median, +9.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, specifically a -1.33% employment growth rate and -0.71% year-over-year wage growth. The combination of these metrics signals a challenging economic environment. The city's labor market is characterized by a low labor demand composite score of 2.14, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -1.33% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.298%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The low labor demand composite score of 2.14, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, further emphasizes the challenges in the labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 3.40%, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with low unemployment. This means that businesses may face difficulties in hiring due to the limited availability of workers, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate suggests that the labor market has slack, but it is still relatively tight.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -0.71%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 0th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are not increasing rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not growing. The stagnant wage growth may make it challenging for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living score ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, with a PSF of $167/sqft and average hourly earnings of $32.76/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.10. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The low affordability score means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living may be a deterrent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is growing at a rate of +0.22% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 51st percentile. This suggests that the labor force supply is slowly expanding, which may provide some relief for businesses looking to hire. However, the slow growth rate may still pose challenges for companies with high hiring demands.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is decreasing at a rate of -0.22% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This indicates that the housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of +9.8%, ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the relatively slow market may also indicate weaker demand.

Office Economy

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has an office economy score ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city may be less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies, but may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with low unemployment, but also poses challenges such as low labor demand, stagnant wage growth, and a high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, which may make it challenging to attract and retain talent, and ultimately impact business growth and profitability.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #45 OF 50

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

C-

CRITICAL

31.9th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	30
Unemployment	20% weight	48
Wage Growth	15% weight	16
Cost of Living	12% weight	16
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	16
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	74
Days on Market	5% weight	20
Office Economy	3% weight	12

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+16.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	43 days	median, -2.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand composite score of 4.38, which ranks in the 30th percentile, and its stagnant wage growth of +1.15% year-over-year, ranking in the 16th percentile. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +0.69% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.889% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the modest job growth is not sufficient to offset the decline in hours worked. This suggests that businesses may face a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 4.80%, ranking in the 48th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This means that the market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +1.15%, ranking in the 16th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and limited growth in worker purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living ratio of $343/sqft to $37.97/hr, with a percentile rank of 16th, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living could be a deterrent for workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is contracting at a rate of -1.39% year-over-year, ranking in the 16th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and retain workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is increasing by +16.17% year-over-year, ranking in the 74th percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce, which could attract more workers and businesses to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 43 days, with a year-over-year decline of -2.3%. This relatively fast pace of home sales means that the market is competitive, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 0.96, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable housing supply and a moderate unemployment rate, but it also presents challenges such as stagnant wage growth, a declining labor force, and a competitive housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the limited labor force growth, which could hinder hiring and expansion plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #46 OF 50

Richmond

Richmond

C-

CRITICAL

31.6th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	10
Unemployment	20% weight	56
Wage Growth	15% weight	36
Cost of Living	12% weight	22
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	31
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	60
Days on Market	5% weight	0
Office Economy	3% weight	26

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.8%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+2.6%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-0.7%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-0.8%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+8.2%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
37 days
median, -13.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand composite score of 3.05, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, and its unemployment rate of 3.80%, which is near the median at the 56th percentile. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.72% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.245%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as hours are being worked above trend during a period of job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This is a concerning sign for businesses looking to hire or expand in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.80%, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This suggests that the market has some slack, but not excessively so, making it neither extremely tight nor very loose. For a business trying to hire in this market, the moderate unemployment rate implies that finding talent may not be overly difficult, but it also may not be extremely easy, with some wage pressure possible.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Richmond is +2.59%, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely quickly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit at a slower pace. This could be seen as a relatively stable environment for businesses, but one where costs are not entirely stagnant.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score that ranks below average at the 22nd percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $229/sqft to $35.37/hr, or 6.47. Given that PSF is increasing by 1.3% year-over-year, this suggests that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. This could make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the higher cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is growing at a rate of -0.80% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in the labor pool. This signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is shrinking. Businesses looking to expand or relocate to Richmond may face challenges in finding the talent they need due to this declining labor force.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Richmond is increasing by 8.22% year-over-year, which is above average and ranks at the 60th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future. However, the current tight market, as indicated by days on market, may not immediately reflect this future improvement.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Richmond is 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 13.9%. This rapid sales pace, ranking at the 0th percentile, indicates a very competitive market that may be challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The fast-moving market could make it difficult for businesses to attract talent from other areas due to the competitive nature of the housing market.

Office Economy

Richmond's professional and office worker share ranks below average at the 26th percentile, with a composite score of 1.70 out of 5. This suggests that the city has a less deep talent pool in professional and office sectors compared to its peers. Richmond is less suited for businesses that require a strong presence of tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

The Richmond metro area presents a mixed bag for businesses considering relocation or expansion, with challenges in labor demand, cost of living, and labor force growth. However, the increasing housing supply, as indicated by building permits, could offer future relief in terms of affordability and accommodation for workers. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight and competitive housing market, which could hinder talent attraction and relocation efforts.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #47 OF 50

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

C-

CRITICAL

29.2th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	22
Unemployment	20% weight	2
Wage Growth	15% weight	14
Cost of Living	12% weight	31
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	94
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	28
Days on Market	5% weight	84
Office Economy	3% weight	38

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+2.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-11.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	38 days	median, +8.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 29.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.96 ranking it at the 22th percentile, and its high unemployment rate of 5.40%, ranking it at the 2th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.24% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.219% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and hours are not increasing. This suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion in the labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 5.40%, ranking it at the 2th percentile. This indicates a slack labor market with a significant number of workers available for hire. For a business trying to hire in this city, the practical implication is that it may be easier to staff, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the high unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +1.06%, ranking it at the 14th percentile. This is a relatively stagnant wage growth rate, indicating that labor costs for employers are not increasing significantly. However, this also means that worker purchasing power is not growing rapidly, which may impact local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living ratio of $186/sqft to $36.54/hr, with a percentile rank of 31. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that the PSF is not falling year-over-year suggests that affordability is not improving. This means that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums to compensate for the higher cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of +2.68% year-over-year, ranking it at the 94th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is expanding rapidly, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire in the city. The implication is that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier to find talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is decreasing at a rate of -10.99% year-over-year. This signals that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This could be a concern for businesses looking to attract and retain talent in the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.6%. This indicates a slower market, ranking it at the 84th percentile. For a worker relocating to this city, this means that the housing market is relatively accessible, with homes taking longer to sell.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 2.10, ranking it at the 38th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and a relatively accessible housing market. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and high unemployment rate, which may impact local consumer demand and make it challenging to find the right talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #48 OF 50

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

C-

CRITICAL

28.2th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	40
Unemployment	20% weight	8
Wage Growth	15% weight	46
Cost of Living	12% weight	35
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	35
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	6
Days on Market	5% weight	10
Office Economy	3% weight	32

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **5.3%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.5%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-28.6%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **33 days** median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 28.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high unemployment rate of 5.30% and its stagnant labor force growth rate of -0.53% YoY. These metrics signal a challenging labor market with limited opportunities for expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.12% YoY, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.375% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.84, which ranks near the median at the 40th percentile. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a slow one. The positive hours deviation indicates that existing workers are shouldering a slightly increased workload, which is a sign of modest labor market tightening.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin stands at 5.30%, ranking it at the 8th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market with significant slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face less competition for talent and may have an easier time staffing their operations. However, the high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +3.22%, ranking it near the median at the 46th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in the area are experiencing a modest increase in their purchasing power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $221/sqft to $37.09/hr, Chicago-Naperville-Elgin ranks at the 35th percentile in terms of affordability. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising by 1.8% YoY relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability concern.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is contracting at a rate of -0.53% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is decreasing. Businesses looking to expand their operations in this city may face challenges in finding the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has decreased by 28.57% YoY, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This sharp decline in permits suggests that the city's affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk in the future, as the supply of new housing units is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 33 days, with no change YoY, ranking it at the 10th percentile. This means that the housing market is relatively hot, with homes selling quickly. For workers relocating to this city, the fast-paced market may make it challenging to find and secure a home.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 1.92, ranking it at the 32nd percentile, Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies. In contrast, it may be less suitable for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely heavily on specialized office workers.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers businesses a relatively loose labor market with moderate wage growth, but its high unemployment rate and stagnant labor force growth pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor market expansion capacity, which may hinder businesses' ability to grow and attract talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #49 OF 50

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

C-

CRITICAL

27.1th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	20
Unemployment	20% weight	70
Wage Growth	15% weight	30
Cost of Living	12% weight	8
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	0
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	22
Days on Market	5% weight	2
Office Economy	3% weight	10

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-8.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-15.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	33 days	median, -8.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 27.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand composite score of 3.84, ranking below average at the 20th percentile, and its extremely low labor force growth rate of -8.76% YoY. The combination of these metrics signals significant challenges for businesses looking to expand or relocate in this area.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -0.33% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.923% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs and hours worked are below trend. This scenario suggests that businesses may face a challenging environment for expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 4.20%, ranking above average at the 70th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +2.03%, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. While this may be beneficial for worker purchasing power, it also means that businesses may face increasing labor costs over time.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living percentile rank of 8th, with a PSF of $224/sqft and average hourly earnings of $32.46/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.90. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, which may make it difficult to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising 6.2% YoY relative to wages further exacerbates this issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is contracting at a rate of -8.76% YoY, ranking at the 0th percentile. This significant decline in labor force supply signals a major structural headwind for hiring, making it extremely challenging for businesses to find and recruit new employees.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -15.25%, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, potentially exacerbating the challenges faced by businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 33 days, with a YoY direction of -8.3%. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. However, the declining days on market may also signal a normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has an office economy percentile rank of 10th, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies. In contrast, tech, finance, or consulting businesses may find it challenging to attract the specialized talent they need.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with moderate wage growth, but its extremely low labor force growth rate and expensive cost of living pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's declining labor force supply, which may limit the ability of businesses to expand or relocate in this area.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #50 OF 50

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

D

EMERGENCY

17.7th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	6
Unemployment	20% weight	2
Wage Growth	15% weight	18
Cost of Living	12% weight	33
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	47
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	8
Days on Market	5% weight	72
Office Economy	3% weight	4

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-27.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	40 days	median, +5.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 17.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.57. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with employment growth of -0.47% year-over-year, and its high unemployment rate of 5.20%, which is in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.47% year-over-year, and weekly hours are 1.071% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as hours are above trend during a period of job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze. This suggests that remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 5.20%, which is in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This indicates a slack labor market, where it may be easier for businesses to hire, but local consumer demand may be weaker. For a business trying to hire in this city, the high unemployment rate means that there may be a larger pool of available workers, but it also suggests that the local economy may not be driving strong demand for products and services.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is +1.17%, which is in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. For workers, this means that purchasing power is increasing, but at a relatively slow rate.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Louisville-Jefferson County is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 33, and a price-to-salary ratio of $179/sqft vs $30.70/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.83. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live and work in the area without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is growing at a rate of +0.08% year-over-year, which is near the median at the 47th percentile. This slow growth rate suggests that the workforce supply is expanding, but at a relatively slow pace. For businesses, this means that hiring capacity may be limited, and it may be necessary to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County is decreasing at a rate of -27.55% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This sharp decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Louisville-Jefferson County is 40 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.3%, resulting in a percentile rank of 72. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this trend may also indicate a weakening demand for housing, which could have implications for the local economy.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Louisville-Jefferson County is 0.44, which is in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a slowing housing market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the low labor demand and high unemployment rate, which may limit hiring capacity and suggest a weaker local economy. Overall, businesses should carefully consider these factors when making a location decision, and weigh the potential benefits and drawbacks of operating in this city.